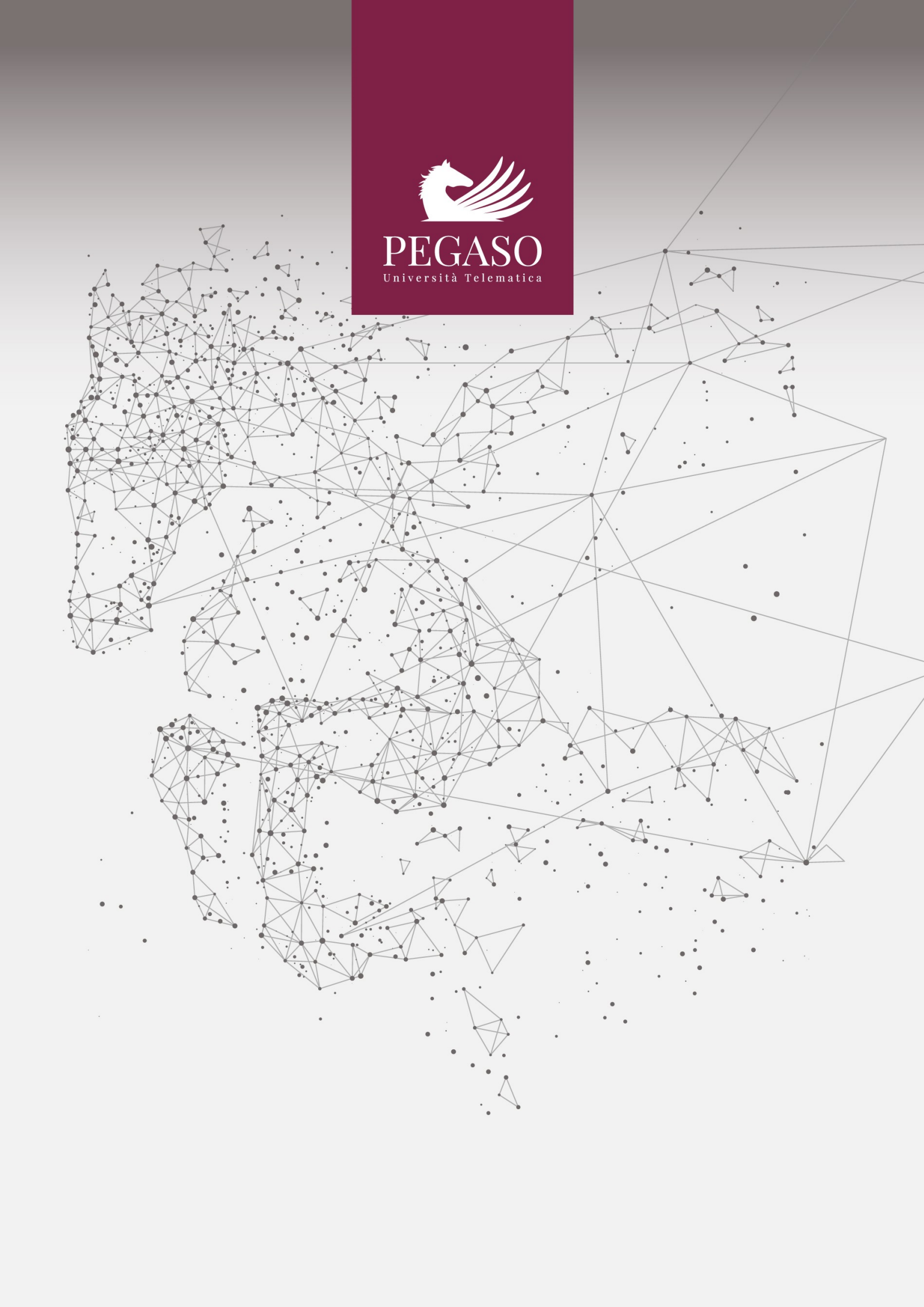

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1. Introduction to Present Tenses

Two Present Tenses

Most English verbs have two present tenses. Forms like I wait, she thinks are called 'simple present' or 'present simple'; forms like I am waiting or she s thinking are called 'present progressive' or 'present continuous'. The two present tenses are used in different ways.

General time: Simple Present

When we talk about permanent situations, or about things that happen regularly or all the time (not just around now), we usually use the simple present.

My parents live near Dover.

Water freezes at 0 Celsius.

I go to London about three times a week.

Around now: Present Continuous

When we talk about temporary continuing actions and events, which are just going on now or around now, we usually use a present progressive tense.

What are you doing? ~ I'm reading.

I'm travelling a lot these days.

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2. Present Simple and Present Continuous

Present Simple (I do)

Study this example situation:

Alex is a bus driver, but now he is in bed asleep.

He is not driving a bus. (He is asleep.) but He drives a bus. (He is a bus driver.)

Drive(s)/work(s)/do(es) etc. is the present simple:

I/we/you/they drive/work/do etc.

he/she/it drives/works/does etc.

We use the present simple to talk about things in general. We use it to say that something happens all the time or repeatedly, or that something is true in general:

- Nurses look after patients in hospitals.
- I usually go away at weekends.
- The earth goes round the sun.
- The café opens at 7.30 in the morning.

Remember:

I work ... but He works... They teach ... but My sister teaches ...

We use do/does to make questions and negative sentences:

Do + I/ we/ you/ they + work?

Does + she/ he/ it + drive?

I/ we/ you / they + don't work

She/ he/ it doesn't drive

- What does this word mean? (What means this word?)
- Rice doesn't grow in cold climates.
- I come from Canada. Where do you come from?
- I don't get away very often.

In the following examples, DO is also the main verb (do you do / doesn't do etc.):

• 'What do you do?' I work in a shop.'

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• He's always so lazy. He doesn't do anything to help.

We use the present simple to say how often we do things:

- I get up at 8 o'clock every morning.
- How often do you go to the dentist?
- Julie doesn't drink tea very often.
- Robert usually goes away two or three times a year.

I promise / I apologize etc.

Sometimes we do things by saying something. For example, when you promise to do something, you can say 'I promise...'; when you suggest something, you can say 'I suggest …'

- I promise I won't be late. (I'm promising)
- 'What do you suggest I do?' I suggest that you ...'

In the same way we say: I apologize ... / I advise ... / I insist... / I agree ... / I refuse ... etc.

Spelling of third person singular forms:

Most verbs:

add -s to infinitive

work → works

sit → sits s

tay → stays

Verbs ending in consonant + y: change y to i and add -es

But (vowel + y):

cry → cries hurry → hurries reply → replies enjoy → enjoys

Verbs ending in -s, -z, -ch, -sh or -x: add -es to infinitive

miss → misses buzz → buzzes watch → watches push → pushes fix → fixes

Exceptions:

have → has go → goes do → does

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Pronunciation of final –s and –*es*

English has three sounds for the letter "s." You have to pay attention to the final sound *before* the s.

Voiceless sounds: /s/ (Voiceless sounds = **p**, **t**, **c** (**k**, **q**), **f**, **h**, **s**, and **x**)

Voiced sounds: /z/ (Voiced sounds = **b**, **d**, **g**, **l**, **r**, **m**, **n**, **z**, and **v)**

The sounds in **s, z, sh, ch, j, g**: /ɪz/

Present continuous (I am doing)

Study this example situation:

Sarah is in her car. She is on her way to work.

She is driving to work.

This means: she is driving now, at the time of speaking.

The action is not finished.

Am/is/are + -ing is the present continuous:

I am (= I'm) driving

he/she/it is (= he's etc.) working

we/you/they are (= we're etc.) doing etc.

I am doing something = I'm in the middle of doing it; I've started doing it and I haven't finished yet:

- Please don't make so much noise. I'm trying to work. (I try)
- "Where's Mark?' 'He's having a shower.' (He has a shower)
- Let's go out now. It isn't raining any more. (It doesn't rain)
- (at a party) Hello, Jane. Are you enjoying the party? (Do you enjoy)
- What's all that noise? What's going on? (= What's happening?)

The action is not necessarily happening at the time of speaking. For example:

Steve is talking to a friend on the phone.

He says: I'm reading a really good book at the moment.

It's about a man who ….

Steve is not reading the book at the time of speaking.

He means that he has started it, but has not finished it yet.

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He is in the middle of reading it.

Some more examples:

- Kate wants to work in Italy, so she's learning Italian. (but perhaps she isn't learning Italian at the time of speaking)
- Some friends of mine are building their own house. They hope to finish it next summer.

You can use the present continuous with today / this week / this year etc. (periods around now):

• A: You're working hard today. (You work hard today)

B: Yes, I have a lot to do.

• The company I work for isn't doing so well this year.

We use the present continuous when we talk about changes happening around now, especially with these verbs:

get change become increase rise fall grow improve begin start

- Is your English getting better? (Does your English get better)
- The population of the world is increasing very fast. (increases)
- At first I didn't like my job, but I'm beginning to enjoy it now. (I begin)

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3. Present Simple vs. Present Continuous

Present continuous vs. Present simple (Part 1)

Present continuous (I am doing)

We use the continuous for things happening at or around the time of speaking.

Present simple (I do)

We use the simple for things in general or things that happen repeatedly. The action is not complete.

Present continuous

- The water is boiling. Can you turn it off?
- Listen to those people. What language are they speaking?
- Let's go out. It isn't raining now.
- "What are you doing?"
- I'm getting hungry. Let's go and eat.
- Kate wants to work in Italy, so she's learning Italian.
- The population of the world is increasing very fast.

We use the continuous for temporary situations:

- I'm living with some friends until I find a place of my own.
- A: You're working hard today. B: Yes, I have a lot to do.

Present simple

- Water boils at 100 degrees Celsius.
- Excuse me, do you speak English?
- It doesn't rain very much in summer.
- What do you usually do at weekends?
- I always get hungry in the afternoon.
- Most people learn to swim when they are children.
- Every day the population of the world increases by about 200,000 people.

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We use the simple for permanent situations:

My parents live in London. They have lived there all their lives.

John isn't lazy. He works hard most of the time.

Difference between present simple and continuous: I always do and I'm always doing

"I always do"

I always do (something) = I do it every time:

I always go to work by car. (I'm always doing…)

"I'm always doing something" has a different meaning.

For example:

I've lost my pen again. I'm always losing things. = I lose things very often, perhaps too often, or more often than normal.

Two more examples:

You're always watching television. You should do something more active.
(= You watch television too often)

dTim is never satisfied. He's always complaining. (= He complains too much)

Present continuous vs. present simple (part 2)

(*I am doing* and *I do*)

We use continuous forms for actions and happenings that have started but not finished (they are eating / it is raining etc.). Some verbs (for example, know and like) are not normally used in this way. We don't say 'I am knowing' or 'they are liking'; we say 'I know', they like.

The following verbs are not normally used in the present continuous: like love hate want need prefer know realize suppose mean understand believe remember belong fit contain consist seem

- I'm hungry. I want something to eat. (I'm wanting)
- Do you understand what I mean?
- Ann doesn't seem very happy at the moment.

Think

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When think means 'believe' or 'have an opinion', we do not use the continuous:

- I think Mary is Canadian, but I'm not sure. (I'm thinking)
- What do you think about my plan? (= What is your opinion?)

When think means 'consider', the continuous is possible:

- I'm thinking about what happened. I often think about it.
- Nicky is thinking of giving up her job. (= she is considering it)

He is selfish **and** He is being selfish

He's being = He's behaving / He's acting. Compare:

- I can't understand why he's being so selfish. He isn't usually like that.

  (being selfish = behaving selfishly at the moment)
- He never thinks about other people. He is very selfish. (He is being)

  (= He is selfish generally, not only at the moment)

We use *am/is/are* being to say how somebody is behaving. It is not usually possible in other sentences:

- It's hot today. (It is being hot)
- Sarah is very tired. (is being tired)

See / hear / smell / taste

We normally use the present simple (not continuous) with these verbs:

- Do you see that man over there? (Are you seeing)
- This room smells. Let's open a window.

We often use **can + see/hear/smell/taste:**

• I can hear a strange noise. Can you hear it?

Look / feel

You can use the present simple or continuous to say how somebody looks or feels now:

- You look well today. or You're looking well today.
- How do you feel now? or How are you feeling now?

but

• I usually feel tired in the morning. (I'm usually feeling

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Exercises

Use the words in brackets to make sentences.

1. (what / you / do?)
2. (you / not / seem / very happy today)
3. (What / think about / politics?)
4. Be quiet! (I / think)
5. (the dinner / smell / good)
6. (who / this umbrella / belong to?)

Put the verb into the correct form, present continuous or present simple.

7. Are you hungry?

ex. Do you want something to eat?

8. Don't put the dictionary away.

(use) it.

9. Don't put the dictionary away:

(need) it.

10. Who is that man?

What (he / want)?

11. Who is that man?

Why (he / look) at us?

Complete the sentences using the most suitable form of be. Sometimes you must use the simple (am/is/are) and sometimes the continuous is more suitable (am/is/are being).

12. I can't understand why (ex. he's being) so selfish. He isn't usually like that.
13. Sarah_____ very nice to me at the moment. I wonder why.
14. You'll like Debbie when you meet her. She _____ very nice.
15. You're usually very patient, so why _____ so unreasonable about waiting ten more minutes?
16. Why isn't Steve at work today? _____ill?

Put the verb into the correct form, present continuous or present simple.

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17. Let's go out. It isn't raining_____(not / rain) now.

18. Julia is very good at languages. She _____ (speak) four languages very well.

19. Hurry up! Everyone_____(wait) for you.

20._____(you / listen) to the radio?" 'No, you can turn it off.'

21._____(you / listen) to the radio every day?' "No, just occasionally.'

22. The River Nile _____ (flow) into the Mediterranean.

23. The river _____(flow) very fast today - much faster than usual.

24. We usually_____ (grow) vegetables in our garden, but this year we _____(not / grow) any.

25. A: How's your English? B: Not bad. I think it_____(improve) slowly.

26. Rachel is in London at the moment. She_____(stay) at the Park Hotel. She always_____(stay) there when she's in London.

Finish B's sentences. Use always **-ing**.

27. A: I've lost my pen again.

B: Not again! ex. You're always losing it.

28. A: The car has broken down again.

B: That car is useless. It _____

29. A: Look! You've made the same mistake again.

B: Oh no, not again! I _____.

30. A: Oh, I've forgotten my glasses again.

B: Typical!_____

31. Translate the following text into Italian.

The company has its main headquarters in the south of Germany. Its employees are international while the CEO is German. The company is beginning to expand into other European countries. It believes this change will be beneficial to their growth. Their legal team has their hands full while all these changes are happening.

Exercise answer key

1. What are you doing?

2. You don't seem very happy today.

3. What do you think about politics?

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4. Be quiet! I'm thinking.

5. The dinner smells good.

6. Who does this umbrella belong to?

7. Do you want something to eat?

8. I'm using it.

9. I need it.

10. What does he want?

11. Why is he looking at us?

12. …he's being so selfish.

13. Sarah is being very nice to me at the moment.

14. She is very nice.

15. Why are you being so unreasonable about waiting 10 more minutes?

16. Is he ill?

17. It isn't raining now.

18. She speaks four languages very well.

19. Everyone is waiting for you.

20. Are you listening to the radio?

21. Do you listen to the radio every day?

22. The River Nile flows into the Mediterranean.

23. The river is flowing very fast today.

24. We usually grow vegetables in our garden, but this year we aren't growing any.

25. I think it is improving slowly.

26. She is staying at the park hotel. She always stays there when she's in London.

27. You're always losing it.

28. It's always breaking down.

29. I'm always making mistakes.

30. I'm always forgetting my glasses.

31. L'azienda ha la sua sede principale nel sud della Germania. I suoi dipendenti sono internazionali, mentre il CEO è tedesco. L'azienda sta iniziando ad espandersi in altri Paesi europei. Ritiene che questo cambiamento sarà vantaggioso per la sua crescita. Il team legale ha il suo bel da fare durante tutti questi cambiamenti.

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